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Civilization: Economic Prosperity

الحمد لله نحمده ونستعينه ونستغفره، ونعوذ بالله تعالى من شرور أنفسنا، وسيئات أعمالنا، ، وأشهد أن لا إله إلا الله وحده لا شريك له، وأشهد أن محمداً عبده ورسوله، اللهم صلّ وسلم وبارك على سيدنا محمد وعلى آله وأصحابه ومن تبعه إلى يوم الدين

This is the fourth talk in the series on **The Qur'an: A Blueprint for Civilization and Salvation**. We saw that the civilization the Qur'an seeks to establish rests upon seven interdependent pillars:

1. Moral and ethical foundation
2. Governance and justice
3. Knowledge and education
- 4. Economic prosperity**
5. Science and technology
6. Defense and security
7. Cultural and artistic flourishing

We discussed the first three pillars of the Qur'anic civilization: **the moral and ethical foundation, Governance, and Knowledge and education**.

Today, in sha' Allah, we move to the fourth pillar: **Economic prosperity**.

A robust economy provides the resources necessary to invest in every other pillar of civilization. This pillar encompasses efficient food production, trade, diverse industries, wealth creation, stable currency, infrastructure, and the specialized labor that sustains all economic activity.

The Qur'an's approach is promoting productive enterprise and private ownership and encouraging wealth while insisting on justice, charity, accountability, and protection from exploitation, and the systemic transfer of wealth from the poor to the powerful

1. The Foundation: Lawful Provision

The Qur'an begins its economic guidance with a foundational principle: Allah has provided good things for human beings, and that they are permitted to enjoy them, with gratitude and within limits:

يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ كُلُوا مِمَّا فِي الْأَرْضِ حَلَالًا طَيِّبًا وَلَا تَتَّبِعُوا خُطُوَاتِ الشَّيْطَانِ إِنَّهُ لَكُمْ عَدُوٌّ مُبِينٌ

"O mankind, eat from whatever is on earth that is lawful and good, and do not follow the footsteps of Satan. Indeed, he is to you a clear enemy." (Al-Baqarah 2:168)

The Qur'an repeatedly combines the concepts of Halal (lawful) and Tayyib (good, wholesome, and beneficial). This frames the entire Qur'anic economic vision: the goal is not merely wealth, but wealth that is clean in its source, honest in its production, and beneficial in its use.

Allah further assures humanity that provision is ultimately His responsibility, removing the anxiety that drives exploitation and hoarding:

وَمَا مِنْ دَابَّةٍ فِي الْأَرْضِ إِلَّا عَلَى اللَّهِ رِزْقُهَا وَيَعْلَمُ مُسْتَقَرَّهَا وَمُسْتَوْدَعَهَا كُلٌّ فِي كِتَابٍ مُبِينٍ

"There is no moving creature on earth but its sustenance depends on Allah. He knows its resting place and its repository. All is in a clear record." (Hud 11:6)

This verse is not a call to passivity; it is a call to trust: to work honestly, trade fairly, and give generously, knowing that provision ultimately comes from Allah and that anxiety about scarcity does not justify dishonesty or exploitation.

2. The Permission of Trade and the Prohibition of Usury (Riba)

The most distinctive and consequential economic ruling in the Qur'an is its absolute prohibition of Riba, commonly translated as usury or interest. This prohibition is stated in the most emphatic terms possible:

وَأَحَلَّ اللَّهُ الْبَيْعَ وَحَرَّمَ الرِّبَا

"...And Allah has permitted trade and forbidden usury." (Al-Baqarah 2: 275)

This single verse establishes the Qur'anic economic framework in one sentence. Trade, which involves real exchange, shared risk, and genuine value creation, is permitted and encouraged. Usury, which generates money from money without productive activity and transfers risk entirely onto the borrower, is forbidden.

The Qur'an escalates its warning progressively. First, it prohibits the compounding form of usury that was common in pre-Islamic Arabia:

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا لَا تَأْكُلُوا الرِّبَا أَضْعَافًا مُضَاعَفَةً وَاتَّقُوا اللَّهَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُفْلِحُونَ (١٣٠)

"O you who have believed, do not consume usury, doubled and multiplied, but fear Allah that you may be successful." (Al-Imran 3:130)

Then it commands the complete abandonment of all remaining usurious dealings, with a warning of extraordinary severity:

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا اتَّقُوا اللَّهَ وَذَرُوا مَا بَقِيَ مِنَ الرِّبَا إِن كُنْتُمْ مُؤْمِنِينَ (٢٧٨) فَإِنْ لَّمْ تَفْعَلُوا فَأْذَنُوا بِحَرْبٍ مِّنَ اللَّهِ وَرَسُولِهِ وَإِنْ تُبْتُمْ فَلَكُمْ رُءُوسُ أَمْوَالِكُمْ لَا تَظْلِمُونَ وَلَا تُظْلَمُونَ (٢٧٩)

"O you who have believed, fear Allah and give up what remains of usury, if you are believers. (278) If you do not, then be informed of a war from Allah and His Messenger. But if you repent, you may keep your principal. Do not wrong others and you will not be wronged." (Al-Baqarah 2:278-279)

The phrase "a war from Allah and His Messenger" is among the most severe warnings in the entire Qur'an. It is reserved for a practice that the Qur'an identifies as systemically unjust: one that concentrates wealth, enslaves the poor to debt, and rewards those who do nothing productive at the expense of those who labor and struggle.

The relevance of this prohibition is profound. Many economists and ethicists have observed that highly debt-dependent financial systems can contribute to wealth concentration, financial instability, and recurring cycles of economic crisis. The Qur'anic prohibition of Riba addresses concerns about precisely these kinds of structural injustices.

3. Mutual Consent and the Ethics of Trade

While prohibiting exploitation, the Qur'an enthusiastically endorses trade conducted based on mutual agreement and consent:

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا لَا تَأْكُلُوا أَمْوَالَكُمْ بَيْنَكُمْ بِالْبَاطِلِ إِلَّا أَنْ تَكُونَ تِجَارَةً عَنْ تَرَاضٍ مِّنْكُمْ

"O you who have believed, do not consume one another's wealth unjustly but only through trade by mutual consent among you." (Al-Nisa 4:29)

The principle of mutual consent, Taradin (تراض), is the ethical heart of all legitimate commerce. It rules out deception, coercion, monopoly, information asymmetry exploited for gain, and any transaction where one party is disadvantaged without their knowledge.

A market governed by genuine mutual consent is one in which both parties benefit, trust is built, and commerce serves its proper civilizational function

4. Fair Weights and Measures: The Foundation of Market Integrity

The Qur'an connects the cosmic order to the requirement for honesty in commerce in a passage of striking beauty and logic:

وَالسَّمَاءَ رَفَعَهَا وَوَضَعَ الْمِيزَانَ (٧) أَلَّا تَطْغَوْا فِي الْمِيزَانِ (٨) وَأَقِيمُوا الْوَزْنَ بِالْقِسْطِ وَلَا تُخْسِرُوا الْمِيزَانَ (٩)
"And the heaven He raised and imposed the balance. (7) So that you do not transgress the balance. (8) And establish weight with justice and do not make deficient in balance." (Al-Rahman 55:7-9)

The structure of this passage is deliberate and profound. Allah raises the heaven and establishes the balance of the cosmos. He then commands human beings to reflect that same balance in their commercial dealings. Dishonest weights and measures are not merely a market infraction. They are a violation of the divine order itself. The same principle is restated as a direct command:

وَأَوْفُوا الْكَيْلَ وَالْمِيزَانَ بِالْقِسْطِ

"Give full measure and weight in justice." (Al-Anaam 6:152)

The practical implications for a modern economy are direct:

- accurate financial reporting,
- transparent pricing,
- honest advertising,
- reliable standards and measurements in industry and trade, and
- the integrity of contracts.

A civilization that applies this principle builds the commercial trust on which all productive economic activity depends.

5. Charity (Zakat/Sadaqah) and Spending in God's Way

The Qur'an's economic system is not simply a free market with ethical guardrails. It includes a mandatory redistribution mechanism, Zakah, which is one of the five pillars of Islam and a cornerstone of the Qur'anic economic order. The parable of charitable spending captures its transformative power:

مَثَلُ الَّذِينَ يُنْفِقُونَ أَمْوَالَهُمْ فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ كَمَثَلِ حَبَّةٍ أَتَتْ سَبْعَ سَنَابِلَ فِي كُلِّ سُنبُلَةٍ مِائَةٌ حَبَّةٌ وَاللَّهُ يُضَاعِفُ لِمَن يَشَاءُ وَاللَّهُ وَاسِعٌ عَلِيمٌ (٢٦١)

"The example of those who spend their wealth in the way of Allah is like a seed [of grain] which grows seven spikes; in each spike is a hundred grains. And Allah multiplies [His reward] for whom He wills. And Allah is all-Encompassing and Knowing." (Al-Baqarah 2: 261)

One seed produces seven hundred grains. The parable illustrates a profound economic principle: wealth that circulates through charity and productive spending benefits far more people than wealth that remains idle or hoarded.

The Qur'an then specifies precisely who is entitled to receive Zakah, establishing in effect a comprehensive social welfare system:

إِنَّمَا الصَّدَقَتُ لِلْفُقَرَاءِ وَالْمَسْكِينِ وَالْعَمِلِينَ عَلَيْهَا وَالْمُؤَلَّفَةِ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَفِي الرِّقَابِ وَالْغَرَمِينَ وَفِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ وَأَبْنِ السَّبِيلِ فَرِيضَةً مِّنَ اللَّهِ وَاللَّهُ عَلِيمٌ حَكِيمٌ (٦٠)

"The charity (Zakah) are only for the poor and for the needy and for those employed to collect [zakah] and for bringing hearts together [for Islam] and for freeing captives [or slaves] and for those in debt and for the cause of Allah and for the [stranded] traveler - an obligation [imposed] by Allah. And Allah is Knowing and Wise." (Al-Tawba 9:60)

The eight categories of Zakah recipients form a social safety net of remarkable comprehensiveness. They cover poverty relief, debt relief, freedom from bondage, support for travelers, community cohesion, and public service.

A state that implements Zakah faithfully does not need to leave its vulnerable citizens without support. It builds, through a religiously motivated wealth transfer, the foundations of a just and inclusive economy.

The Qur'an pairs this with the command to establish prayer alongside Zakah, signaling that economic justice is not separate from spiritual life. It is an expression of it:

وَأَقِيمُوا الصَّلَاةَ وَآتُوا الزَّكَاةَ وَأَطِيعُوا الرَّسُولَ لَعَلَّكُمْ تُرْحَمُونَ

"And establish prayer and give Zakah and obey the Messenger, that you may receive mercy." (Al-Nur 24:56)

6. The Prohibition of Waste and Extravagance

The Qur'an is unambiguous in its condemnation of wasteful spending. Economic resources are a trust from Allah, and squandering them is a moral failure with social consequences:

وَأَبِ ذَا الْقُرْبَىٰ حَقَّهُ وَالْمِسْكِينَ وَابْنَ السَّبِيلِ وَلَا تَبْذُرْ تَبْذِيرًا (٢٦) إِنَّ الْمُبْذِرِينَ كَانُوا إِخْوَانَ الشَّيَاطِينِ ۚ وَكَانَ الشَّيْطَانُ لِرَبِّهِ كَفُورًا (٢٧)

" And give the relative his due right, and the needy and the traveler, and do not spend wastefully. (26) Indeed, the wasteful are brothers of the devils, and ever has Satan been to his Lord ungrateful." (Al-Isra 17:26-27)

Waste is here described not as a minor personal failing but as a form of ingratitude to Allah and a kinship with destructive forces. The economic logic is clear: every resource wasted is a resource that could have served a productive purpose or relieved a genuine need.

A civilization that cultivates discipline in spending, whether at the household, institutional, or governmental level, preserves and multiplies its wealth. One that normalizes extravagance exhausts it.

The Qur'an equally condemns the opposite extreme of miserliness, prescribing a middle path between the two:

وَلَا تَجْعَلْ يَدَكَ مَغْلُولَةً إِلَىٰ عُنُقِكَ وَلَا تَبْسُطْهَا كُلَّ الْبَسْطِ فَتَقْعَدَ مَلُومًا مَّحْسُورًا

"And do not make your hand chained to your neck, nor extend it completely, lest you sit blamed and insolvent." (Al-Isra 17:29)

The balanced economy the Qur'an envisions is neither miserly nor extravagant. It spends what needs to be spent, gives what is due, saves what is prudent, and neither hoards nor squanders.

7. The Prohibition of Hoarding and the Danger of Wealth Obsession

The Qur'an is particularly severe in its condemnation of those who accumulate wealth as an end in itself, treating it as a source of immortality:

وَيْلٌ لِّكُلِّ هُمَزَةٍ لُّمَزَةٍ (١) الَّذِي جَمَعَ مَالًا وَعَدَّدَهُ، (٢) يَحْسَبُ أَنَّ مَالَهُ أَخْلَدَهُ، (٣)

"Woe to every scorner and mocker, (1) who collects wealth and counts it repeatedly, (2) thinking that his wealth will make him immortal." (Al-Humazah 104:1-3)

This surah addresses a psychological and civilizational disease: the delusion that wealth is the ultimate source of security. A society organized around this delusion:

- concentrates wealth in the hands of those most willing to hoard it,
- strips resources from productive circulation, and
- produces inequality and social fracture

that eventually destabilize even the most materially prosperous civilizations.

The Qur'an also warns directly against those who accumulate gold and silver without spending in the way of Allah:

وَالَّذِينَ يَكْنِزُونَ الذَّهَبَ وَالْفِضَّةَ وَلَا يَنْفِقُونَهَا فِي سَبِيلِ اللَّهِ فَبَشِّرْهُمْ بِعَذَابٍ أَلِيمٍ

"And those who hoard gold and silver and do not spend it in the way of Allah: give them tidings of a painful punishment." (Al-Tawbah 9:34)

The economic principle here is that wealth must circulate to serve its social function. Money withdrawn from productive circulation and held solely for accumulation violates the Qur'anic economic order.

8. The Prohibition of Exploitation and Corruption in Commerce

The Qur'an forbids every form of economic exploitation: the taking of others' wealth by false means, the manipulation of markets, and the use of political or judicial power to extract economic advantage:

وَلَا تَأْكُلُوا أَمْوَالَكُمْ بَيْنَكُمْ بِالْبَاطِلِ وَتُدْلُوا بِهَا إِلَى الْحُكَّامِ لِتَأْكُلُوا فَرِيقًا مِّنْ أَمْوَالِ النَّاسِ بِالْإِثْمِ وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ

"And do not consume one another's wealth unjustly, nor use it to bribe judges in order to consume a portion of the people's wealth sinfully, while you know." (Al-Baqarah 2:188)

The Qur'an also invokes the principle of not causing corruption in the land as an economic command:

وَلَا تَبْغِ الْفُسَادَ فِي الْأَرْضِ إِنَّ اللَّهَ لَا يُحِبُّ الْمُفْسِدِينَ

"And do not seek to cause corruption in the land. Indeed, Allah does not love corrupters." (Al-Qasas 28:77)

Economic corruption, whether through bribery, price manipulation, monopoly, fraud, or the exploitation of desperate people, is described by the Qur'an as Fasad, corruption of the earth itself. It is not a victimless transaction between willing parties. It degrades the entire economic and social environment in which all must live.

9. Work, Productivity, and Ethics of Earning

The Qur'an affirms that honest labor and productive effort are honored by Allah. The earth and its resources are placed at the disposal of human beings for their use and development:

هُوَ الَّذِي جَعَلَ لَكُمُ الْأَرْضَ ذَلُولًا فَامْشُوا فِي مَنَاكِبِهَا وَكُلُوا مِن رِّزْقِهِ ۚ وَإِلَيْهِ النُّشُورُ

"It is He who made the earth manageable for you, so walk in its regions and eat of His provision. And to Him is the resurrection." (Al-Mulk 67:15)

The command to "walk in its regions" is an invitation to economic activity: exploration, agriculture, trade, industry, and all the forms of productive engagement with the earth's resources.

The Qur'an does not honor passivity or dependence when ability and opportunity exist. It honors honest, productive effort as a fulfillment of the human stewardship role on earth.

Conclusion: An Economy Built on Justice, Productivity, and Compassion

The Qur'an's economic vision is a coherent and complete system. It rests on three pillars working in concert:

- Productivity and trade: Encouraging honest work, free commerce, and the development of the earth's resources as acts of worship and stewardship.
- Justice and integrity: Prohibiting usury, exploitation, fraud, bribery, and every form of taking that enriches one party by wronging another.
- Redistribution and compassion: Mandating Zakah and encouraging voluntary charity to ensure that the fruits of economic activity reach the poor, the vulnerable, and the marginalized.

A civilization that implements all three of these principles simultaneously creates an economy that is both dynamic and just: one that grows, that distributes its growth fairly, and that does not consume itself through the systemic injustices that inevitably bring even the wealthiest economies to crisis.

The Qur'an's economic guidance was not written for a medieval agrarian society alone. Its principles address the structural roots of poverty, inequality, financial instability, and corruption that remain the defining economic challenges of our time.

Pillar 5. Science & Technology

Science and technology are among the most powerful drivers of civilizational progress.

The Qur'an is not a science textbook but what it does provide is a worldview that makes science not only permissible but obligatory. It frames the study of the natural world as

an act of worship, the development of the earth as a divine mandate, and the harnessing of creation's resources as a trust granted to humanity by Allah.

1. The Human Mandate: Stewardship and Development of the Earth

The Qur'an presents human beings not as passive inhabitants of the earth but as its builders. Allah says through Prophet Salih:

وَإِلَى ثَمُودَ أَخَاهُمْ صَالِحًا قَالَ يَنْقُومَ آعْبُدُوا اللَّهَ مَا لَكُمْ مِنْ إِلَهٍ غَيْرُهُ هُوَ أَنشَأَكُمْ مِنَ الْأَرْضِ وَاسْتَعْمَرَكُمْ فِيهَا
"He produced you from the earth and settled you in it to develop it." (Hud 11:61)

The word استعمرکم comes from the root عماره; to build, cultivate, develop, and make flourish. This is one of the Qur'an's clearest statements about humanity's mission on earth.

Engineering, medicine, agriculture, architecture, industry, and every beneficial science that improves human life are all part of fulfilling this divine trust. Allah further reminds us

وَسَخَّرَ لَكُمْ مَّا فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ جَمِيعًا مِنْهُ إِنَّ فِي ذَلِكَ لَآيَاتٍ لِّقَوْمٍ يَتَفَكَّرُونَ
"And He has subjected to you whatever is in the heavens and whatever is on the earth, all from Him. Indeed, in that are signs for a people who give thought." (Al-Jathiyah 45:13)

أَلَمْ تَرَوْا أَنَّ اللَّهَ سَخَّرَ لَكُمْ مَّا فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَمَا فِي الْأَرْضِ وَأَسْبَغَ عَلَيْكُمْ نِعَمَهُ ظَاهِرَةً وَبَاطِنَةً
"Do you not see that Allah has made subject to you whatever is in the heavens and whatever is in the earth and has lavished upon you His favors, both apparent and hidden?" (Luqman 31:20)

The apparent blessings are those we immediately recognize, water, food, sunlight, and air. The hidden blessings are those that Allah placed within creation for humanity to discover through observation, and scientific inquiry. Every generation uncovers new secrets of Allah's creation and transforms them into blessings that benefit mankind.

Science and Engineering, therefore, are not foreign to Islam, they are one of the means through which believers fulfill the command to cultivate the earth and appreciate the hidden favors of Allah.

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